

Interface metaphors

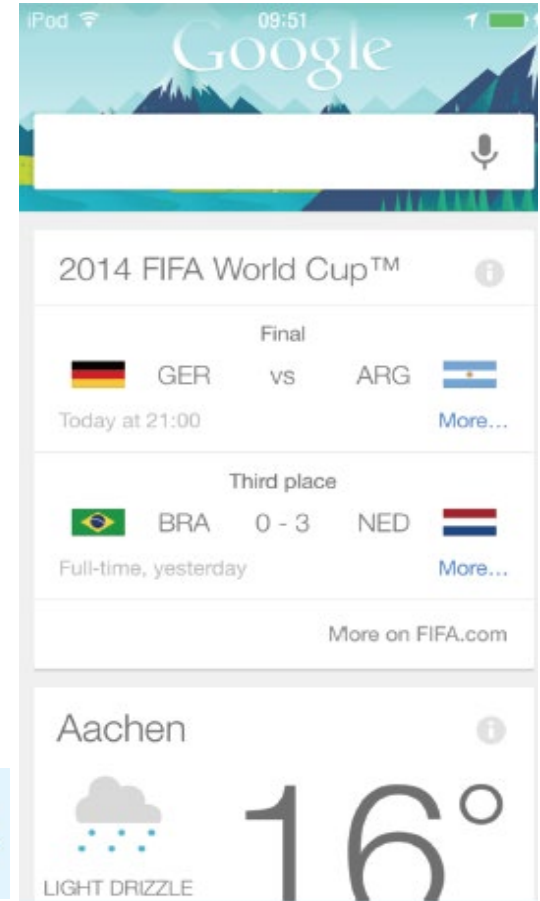
- Conceptualizing what we are doing, e.g. surfing the web
- A conceptual model instantiated at the interface, e.g. the desktop metaphor
- Visualizing an operation, e.g. an icon of a shopping cart for placing items into

Material Metaphors

- The card is a very popular UI
- Why?: Has familiar form factor
- Material properties are added, giving appearance and physical behavior, e.g. surface of paper

Figure 2.5 Google Now Card

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<http://www.google.com/design/spec/material-design/introduction.html>



Activity

- Describe the components of the conceptual model underlying most online shopping websites, e.g.
 - Shopping cart
 - Proceeding to check-out
 - 1-click
 - Gift wrapping
 - Cash till?

Interface metaphors

- Interface designed to be similar to a physical entity but also has own properties
 - e.g. desktop metaphor, web portals
- Can be based on activity, object or a combination of both
- Exploit user's familiar knowledge, helping them to understand 'the unfamiliar'
- Conjures up the essence of the familiar activity, enabling users to leverage this to understand more aspects of the unfamiliar functionality

Benefits of interface metaphors

- Makes learning new systems easier
- Helps users understand the underlying conceptual model
- Can be very innovative and enable the realm of computers and their applications to be made more accessible to a greater diversity of users

Problems with interface metaphors

- Break conventional and cultural rules
 - e.g. recycle bin placed on desktop
- Can constrain designers in the way they conceptualize a problem space
- Conflict with design principles
- Forces users to only understand the system in terms of the metaphor
- Designers can inadvertently use bad existing designs and transfer the bad parts over
- Limits designers' imagination in coming up with new conceptual models